ingly, she suggests that his mausoleum grew out of "Humayun's thought... out of his interest in mathematical sciences... and out of the fruits of his travels". Humayun's Tomb evoked for posterity the Badshah who was buried in it; he was the conceptualist behind the building. Indeed, Koch suggests the tomb is a posthumous realisation of his ideas and dreams.

Now a World Heritage Site, Humayun's Tomb in war photographer Felice Beato's 1857 sepia composition stands testimony to an Indian past lodged in its own ruins. The long shot catches a relatively small tomb in the distance with a pockmarked dome; the majestic gateway of today appears detached, almost unnecessary. Bits of a low wall, a solitary *keekar* tree and two small puddles from a late-September shower, all combine to give the place a sense of oblivious vulnerability. What a sad and ludicrous place for Bahadur Shah, the last Mughal King, to have repaired to after the bloody recapture of Delhi by the British at the end of the Great Revolt of 1857, Beato's sepia photograph of a derelict Humayun's Tomb seems to be telling us. What a waste of time and effort before the march of colonial history.

Of late, Humayun's Tomb seems to have risen from its ashes. A joint venture of the Aga Khan Trust for Culture, the Dorabji Tata Trust and the Archaeological Survey of India has literally peeled away centuries-old detritus of plaster, lime and bird droppings; thoughtful repairs and conservation have brought Humayun, Akbar's father, back to life. Still, the deprecatory adage of a colonial British historian—"Humayun tumbled through life and tumbled out of it"—continues to prevail.

Last week, I caught up with Professor Koch on her umpteenth trip to the Aga Khan Trust's office, nestling amidst the Sunder Nursery landscaped by the innovative architect, the late Mohammad Shaheer. She was accompanied this time by the Scottish sculpturer, Jill Watson, who has created seven bronze statues of Humayun Padshah, sculpting, as it were, the multifaceted personality of Humayun Padshah. Koch once again talked about her life-long interest in the second Mughal King. I listened.

Long ago, Sunder Nursery, Humayun's Tomb and its immediate environs formed an extensive garden, hemmed in on its eastern side by the river Jamuna. That river has now retreated some four miles east, across National Highway 24, to the middle-class urban sprawl of Patparganj ('Patpar': lit. riverside soil retentive of moisture). The tomb of Abdul Rahim Khan-i-Khanan, the Akbar-era popular 'Hindavi' poet of great acuity, is nearby, welcoming, so to speak, the Delhi gentry to their houses in Nizamuddin East. Across the road lies the old basti of Hazrat Nizamuddin, our greatest Sufi saint. Dividing the two habitations, one a product of modernity and the other of an era going back to the 13th century, is the roaring traffic on its way to Lutyens' Delhi. ■

***Shahid Amin** is a former professor of history at Delhi University*

**THE PLANETARY KING**
*by Ebba Koch*
AGA KHAN TRUST FOR CULTURE AND MAPIN PUBLISHING
**₹3,950; 384** pages




the use of newsletters to assert their agency against the Company. The emperors even sent emissaries—Raja Ram Mohan Roy by Akbar II, and anti-slavery activist George Thompson by Bahadur Shah Zafar—to England, but both missions found little success. The Company, too, at the beginning wasn't an inexorable force, but went from being a Resident at the Mughal court to ruler of the city.

Liddle's book comes at a time when there is much dust blowing around Mughal rule in India. For those who are motivated to understand colonialism simply as rule by any foreign power, Liddle draws an image of the ground-level view of the workings of the transition between the two powers, and through it emerge the different principles on which these two 'foreign' orders were built. The Mughal rulers distinguished themselves via a substantive tolerance of religions and traditions, which maintained them in the hearts and minds of their subjects. Meanwhile, the British rulers are characterised by parsimony and insolence.

This 'hybrid half-century' housed both the twilight of Mughal rule and what C.F. Andrews calls the Delhi Renaissance. The book examines the social and political culture of the time and how through it all, the late-Mughal city acquired a distinctive modernity. It explores the growth of the Urdu language and poetry, and its proliferation via print, several radical innovations in pedagogy via institutions such as the Delhi College, the Vernacular Translation Society, the advent of the popular press and organisations such as the Archaeological Society, all developments indicative of a city on the cusp of change—till the Revolt of 1857 and its aftermath violently ran it into ruin, rupturing the process.

The book also draws attention to the beginning of the expression of ideas that were precursors to concepts such as nationalism, anti-colonialism and the start of the sectarian divide wedged in by the colonial government in its suppression of the revolt. Strikingly well-researched and with terrific prose, the book knits together a rich, narrative history of the time. Perhaps, there are lessons we can draw from it for our contemporary times. ■

***Naorem Anuja***

***The Broken Script* comes at a time when there's much dust blowing around Mughal rule in India**